

excuse for them to get together and socialize while doing something purposeful. Soon, other embassies started to sell things at the bazaar—maple syrup from the Canadian embassy, handicrafts from Nepal, and perfume from the French embassy. This small group that called itself the United Nations Women’s Guild eventually corralled forty embassies in Geneva to participate. Today, this one-day UN bazaar brings in as much as \$300,000 in sales, all donated to charity. That money has built sports facilities in Bogotá and treated children with cancer in Egypt. My mother was as proud of that work as anything she’d ever done in her life—Money Karma in its purest form.

But give only if you can afford to give, which means only if you’ve paid off all your debts. I like to set aside at least 5 percent of my after-tax income, funneling it to a few select charities that mean something to me and my wife, such as foundations that fight disease, or arts and cultural organizations. We call our charitable donations “five in five.” We select five charities or causes for five years and support those, rather than spreading our focus too widely. After five years pass, we assess and choose five more. The method doesn’t matter; the point is that good Money Karma goes beyond any tax break you’ll receive. There are health benefits to giving. Countless academic studies have come to the same conclusion: Altruistic people live longer, healthier, and happier lives. Therefore, they’re less of a financial burden on their families and on society. You give, you get.

But Money Karma works not only with giving, it works with spending. And midlife is not the time to be messing with that karma.

Money Mistake: The Nest Felt Empty, You Bought a Dog

THE FIX: BUDGET FOR BOWSER BEFORE YOU BUY

The kids are out of the house, you’ve been aggressively paying down your mortgage, you’re almost debt-free, and you’re feeling your Money Karma aligning in the best possible way. Then you go out and get yourself a dog, reversing all that good karma. It’s baffling to me that getting a dog has become synonymous with winding down into